The Robber

By William Heuman

INTRODUCTION

"Which of the two do you want me to release to you?" asked the governor.

"Barabbas," they answered.

"What shall I do, then, with Jesus who is called Christ?" Pilate asked.

They all answered, "Crucify Him!"

"Why? What crime has He committed?" asked Pilate.

But they shouted all the louder, "Crucify Him!"

Barabbas was a notorious criminal who Pilate proposed to execute instead of Jesus. This is his story . . . The Robber by William Heuman.

I have seen men crucified out in the hills. I have seen some of the hills of Galilee covered with the crosses; I have heard men cry out in agony. I have seen them die this slow and most torturous death, but I am not afraid. Never have I been afraid to die. I will spit in their faces when they nail me to the cross; I will laugh at them; I will mock them, and they will wait in vain for my cries. I am Barabbas, and in my body runs the blood of David, mighty warrior, mighty king.

Even here, though, in this hole in the ground where there is no light, where there is only dampness and cold and these dead dreams, there comes yet one small ray of hope. It has been said that the governor is to release a prisoner for the Passover feast. This gesture is to make the governor a trifle more acceptable to the people, who hate him as they hate those who sent him.

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There is a prisoner to be released, and it could be me. My crime was not murder, though some say it is. We fought the Romans and we defeated them, and I am held here for sedition. I will not plead or beg for my life, but if it is given to me I shall not refuse it.

I am not old. I am a young man who has run through the hills, who has drunk from the cool mountain springs, who has eaten lamb in the wild mountains, who has loved women. It is not that I despise life; it is only that I reject cowardice. A man is a man, or he is a dead dog. Life, if miraculously returned to me, I would accept with pleasure, because great pleasures still lie ahead of me.

But I speak foolishness. In this deep hole I would have heard nothing had not the slave who was brought in here to fasten the fetters on my ankles whispered to me that there was this small hope. I would be a fool to magnify such a rumor.
For all I know there are fifty prisoners in this dungeon to be released ahead of Barabbas, the robber. Still a man can hope and he can dream of the high hills, the wind once again ruffling his hair, the warm sun on the side of the mountain in the early morning, and the firelight in the evening. He can remember choice comrades at his side, brave men and true, all dead now except Barabbas who is to die tomorrow.

In the darkness now I see a glow of light, and it has been but a few hours since I ate last. They are not bringing me food. I have no friends to visit me, and no friends are permitted if there were such. The light is coming closer, and I hear

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the rattle of armor and the clank of sword. Now they are at my door, and I see their faces, the hard, cruel Roman faces, the gleam of torchlight on their armor. The slave is with them, grinning, his white teeth like so many ivories. It is he who informs me that I am to be released, and it is he who strikes the chains from my feet with powerful blows of his hammer, the Roman guard watching in cool arrogance.

"You are free," the slave informs me. "The governor has released you, Barabbas, to please the people."

"Man," the Roman tells me scornfully, "They are to crucify another in your place. You will live until we run our swords through you at another place."

"Who is to die for me?" I ask.
"The teacher, Jesus of Nazareth,"

I have heard of him. Indeed, once I saw him in the hills of Galilee when my men came down into a village to forage. I saw him speak with the poor. I saw the crowds about him. I had heard that he was a great healer of many sicknesses, but he was not a warrior. He carried no sword with him, nor did his followers. This was a man of peace, and I did not wait to hear his words. One can talk of peace to the Romans only with the sword in one hand and a buckler in the other. This is the only peace they understand.

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Yet I remember his face, a young man. His face was not like the faces of other men, and I still remember, even though it was several years ago that I saw him. His was a face full of kindness and love, and with no evil in it. This was the face of a god and not a man; not a weak face, but a face where sin could not abide. Many times I have thought of that face, and I have heard much talk of this Jesus in my wanderings and fighting in Judea, in Galilee, in Samaria. I had not known that he, like myself, was a prisoner in this evil place.

"What crime has he done?" I ask the Roman. "He a man without a sword."

"It is not for you to ask questions," the Roman informs me. "Go and pray to your god or we will run you through before you have passed the outer gate."

There is a weakness in my legs as I hurry down the damp, stony corridor, passing one gate and then another until I emerge into the sunlight. I have not seen the sun in many weeks, and I am blinded by it. I want to sing and shout aloud for joy because life is good, but it is then that I remember this Jesus of Nazareth, who is to die in my place. I try to convince myself that it is my good fortune and his loss, but I cannot forget his face. What charges could they have brought against so good and just man? What evil could he have committed?

There are crowds in the street, and all seem to be hastening toward the gate of the city. There seems to be a holiday atmosphere. I touch one man's arm and ask him, "Where is the crowd going, friend?"

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With contempt he looks at my rags, my filth, my blood-caked body. "They are crucifying Jesus of Nazareth this morning," he says, as he hurries on with the others. It is a strange fact that men of peace love the sight of blood and suffering in others.

I follow the crowd out through the gate and off on a hill nearby. The place is called Golgotha, the place of the skull. I see the vast crowd assembled with more and more people streaming out of the city, pushing to get up closer. I see two crosses on the hill, and now a third is being raised against the pale blue sky. It is already done! Barabbas is free, but the man Jesus will never walk the Galilean streets again.

I must see Him. I must see the face that has haunted me through the years. I ask another, "What is the charge against this man, Jesus?"

'Treason against Rome," he says, "and blasphemy against our God."
"Blasphemy!" I repeat.
"He preached that he is the Son of God."

I must see his face before the light of life is gone from it. I push on through the crowd because I am a big man and strong. Curses are hurled at me as I make my way up the hill. I see the priests in their costly robes, watching him on the middle cross. There are some women, followers of his from Galilee, and I hear one say that his mother is here also. Poor woman, to witness this terrible suffering

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of her son! I see the soldiers, their armor gleaming in the sunlight. Some watch the three dying men on the crosses; others play their favorite game of dice.
I see the face now, and it is the same face, pale, drawn with suffering, but there is in it something that never can be erased, not by cruel nails or flagellations or scourgings. Nothing that men can do can take away the love on that face.

His eyes are closed as I come closer and closer. I hear the weeping of the women. I hear the derisive taunts and shouts of those who this day have called for his blood. I hear the ribald curses of the Romans at their game, and I hear the moans of the two thieves crucified with him, one on either side, but no sound comes from him on the middle cross.

I come closer and I stand behind the Romans who kneel at their game. I look up into his face, and he opens his eyes, and he looks down on me. He has never met me; he has never seen me, although I have seen him, but he knows me. This I can see in his eyes. There is compassion, love, the forgiveness of my crimes. He looks at me, and I sink slowly to my knees.

"My Lord," I whisper, "and my God!"

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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